

SANTIAGO TOBÓN, PHD

Universidad EAFIT
School of Finance, Economics and Government
CR 49 # 7Sur-50, Rm. 26-113
Medellín, Colombia 050022

stobonz@eafit.edu.co
<http://santiagotobon.co/>
+57 2619500
Citizenship: Colombian, Spanish

ACADEMIC EMPLOYMENT

2020– Professor of Economics (tenured), Universidad EAFIT
2025– Director, Centro de Valor Público, Universidad EAFIT
2019–20 Professor of Economics (untentured), Universidad EAFIT
2024 Visiting Scholar, UNU – World Institute for Development Economics Research
2023 Visiting Scholar, Interamerican Development Bank
2022 Visiting Professor, University of Chicago Harris School of Public Policy
2017–19 Postdoctoral Scholar, University of Chicago Harris School of Public Policy & Innovations for Poverty Action
2016–17 Doctoral Scholar, Innovations for Poverty Action
2016 Visiting Doctoral Student, University of Chicago Harris School of Public Policy

OTHER AFFILIATIONS

2024– Affiliate, J-PAL—Crime and Violence Initiative
2020– Academic Member, Evidence in Governance and Politics (EGAP); Board Member; Co-director EGAP Latin America
2016– Researcher, Innovations for Poverty Action

EDUCATION

2014–18 Ph.D., Economics, Universidad de los Andes. Dissertation with distinction
2014–17 M.A., Economics, Universidad de los Andes
2011–12 M.A., Economics, Université catholique de Louvain. *Grande distinction*
2009–11 M.A., Business, Universidad EAFIT
2002–07 B.A., Computer Science, Universidad EIA

FIELDS OF STUDY

Political economy, Economics of crime, Development economics, Public policy, Policing, Criminal governance

PRIZES AND HONORS

2024 Medellín Investiga Prize, awarded every year to the best research project related to Medellín's most important development challenges
2020 Juan Luis Londoño Medal, awarded every two years to Colombians of 40 years or less for the impact of their research and policy work on the welfare of Colombians

WORKING PAPERS & PAPERS UNDER REVIEW

"Education and Youth-Development Interventions for Organized-Crime Prevention in Developing Countries: Evidence, Extrapolation, and Policy," with Martín Vanegas-Arias. Under review

"From Schools of Crime to Criminal Hubs? Prisons and Organized Crime in Latin America and the Caribbean," with Ernesto Schargrotsky. Under review

"Respect, Neutrality, and Police Legitimacy: A Representative Vignette Experiment in Post-Conflict Colombia," with Verónica Abril, Santiago Pérez-Vincent, and Martín Vanegas-Arias. Under review

"Who Joins Drug-Selling Gangs and Why? Beliefs and Recruitment Risk among 10,000 Adolescent Boys," with Christopher Blattman and Arantxa Rodríguez-Urbe

"Pax Criminalis," with Christopher Blattman, Gustavo Duncan, Benjamin Lessing, and Juan F. Martínez

"Gangs of Medellín: How Organized Crime Is Organized," with Christopher Blattman, Gustavo Duncan, and Benjamin Lessing

"Building Trust in State Actors: A Multi-Site Experiment with the Colombian National Police," with Verónica Abril, Erynn Norza, Santiago Pérez-Vincent, and Michael Weintraub

"How Illegal Economies and Armed Actors Shape the Vote: Evidence from Colombia's Presidential Elections," with Michael Weintraub

"How Illegal Income Improves Schooling: Cocaine Production and Education in Colombia," with Ivonne Lara, Martín Vanegas-Arias, and Juan Vargas

"Do Illegal Economies Reduce Local Fiscal Capacity?" with Patricia Justino, Martín Vanegas-Arias, and Juan Vargas

BOOKS

2026 *COCAÍNA: Anatomía de un mercado prohibido*. Book manuscript, with the publisher.

ACADEMIC PUBLICATIONS

Journal Articles

- 2026 "Implementation Outcomes of a CBT-Based Psychosocial Intervention for Gang-Recruitment-Vulnerable Youth in Medellín: A Qualitative Study of Novice Provider Experiences," with Gabriela Algarín, Maríantonía Lemos, and Martín Vanegas-Arias, accepted at *Cambridge Prisms: Global Mental Health*.
- 2025 "Statebuilding in the City: An Experiment in Civilian Alternatives to Policing," with Christopher Blattman, Gustavo Duncan, and Benjamin Lessing, accepted at *American Political Science Review*.
- "Gang Rule: Understanding and Countering Criminal Governance," with Christopher Blattman, Gustavo Duncan, and Benjamin Lessing, *Review of Economic Studies* 92(3): 1497–1531.
- 2023 "Production and Persistence of Criminal Skills: Evidence from a High-Crime Context," with Maria A. Escobar and Martin Vanegas-Arias, *Journal of Development Economics* 160: 102969.
- "The Perils of Military Policing," (invited commentary), *Nature Human Behaviour*.
- 2022 "Do Better Prisons Reduce Recidivism? Evidence from a Prison Construction Program," *The Review of Economics and Statistics* 104(6): 1256–1272.
- 2021 "Place-Based Interventions at Scale: The Direct and Spillover Effects of Policing and City Services on Crime," with Christopher Blattman, Donald Green, and Daniel Ortega, *Journal of the European Economic Association* 19(4): 2022–2051.

- “Hot Spots Policing in a High-Crime Environment: An Experimental Evaluation in Medellín,” with Daniel Collazos, Eduardo García, Daniel Mejía, and Daniel Ortega, *Journal of Experimental Criminology* 17(3): 473–506.
- “The Deterrent Effect of Surveillance Cameras on Crime,” with Santiago Gómez and Daniel Mejía, *Journal of Policy Analysis and Management* 40(2): 553–571.
- “Crises Conducting Stakeholder Salience: Shifts in the Evolution of Private Universities’ Governance in Latin America,” with M.A. Gonzalez-Perez, M. Cordova, M. Hermans, K.M. Nava-Aguirre, F. Monje-Cueto, S. Mingo, C.A. Rodriguez, E.H. Salvaj, and D.E. Floriani, *Corporate Governance: The International Journal of Business in Society* 21(6): 1194–1214.
- “Community Policing in the Developing World,” (invited commentary), *Science* 374(6571): 1046–1047.
- 2020 “Meta-Analysis of Hematopoietic Stem Cell Transplantation in Major Histocompatibility Complex Class II Deficiency,” with L.M. Castaño-Jaramillo, J. Bareño-Silva, and A.F. Escobar-Gonzalez, *Pediatric Transplantation* 24(6): e13774.
- 2018 “The Role of Land Property Rights in the War on Illicit Crops: Evidence from Colombia,” with Juan Carlos Muñoz-Mora and Jesse W. d’Anjou, *World Development* 103: 268–283.
- Book Chapters*
- Forth. “Crime: Economics of, the Standard Approach,” with Paolo Buonanno and Juan F. Vargas, in *Encyclopedia of Law and Economics*, A. Marciano and G.B. Ramello, Eds., Springer.
- 2022 “Prisons,” with Paolo Buonanno and Juan F. Vargas, in *Encyclopedia of Law and Economics*, A. Marciano and G.B. Ramello, Eds., Springer, pp. 1–5.
- “Broken Windows Policing and Crime: Evidence from 80 Colombian Cities,” with Daniel Mejía, Elkin Norza, and Martin Vanegas-Arias, in *A Modern Guide to the Economics of Crime*, P. Buonanno, P. Vanin, and J. Vargas, Eds., Edward Elgar Publishing, pp. 55–87.

PROFESSIONAL ACTIVITIES

Teaching

- 2019– Universidad EAFIT: Microeconomics Seminar—Economics of Crime (undergraduate); Microeconomics Seminar—Development Economics (undergraduate); Political Economy (undergraduate); Impact Evaluation (graduate)
- 2022 University of Chicago Harris School of Public Policy: Economic Development and Policy (graduate); International Police Reform Policy Lab (graduate)
- 2016– National Police of Colombia (lecturer): Evidence Based Policing (graduate-equivalent)
- 2017–19 American University (lecturer): Policing in the Global Context (undergraduate)
- 2015 Universidad de los Andes (teaching assistant): Economic Theory of Crime (graduate)

PhD Students

- 2023– Martin Vanegas-Arias, Universidad EAFIT (supervision)
- 2020– César Herrera, Universidad EAFIT (supervision)
- 2022 PierFrancesco Rolla, University of Sussex (examination)
- 2021 Magaly Herrera, Universidad ICESI (examination)

Refereeing

Science; Nature; Quarterly Journal of Economics; American Political Science Review; AER: Insights; Review of Economics and Statistics; Journal of the European Economic Association; AEJ: Applied; Economic Journal; Journal of Labor Economics; Journal of Development Economics; Journal of Human Resources; Journal of Public Economics; Comparative Political Studies; Journal of Financial and Quantitative Analysis; Nature Human Behavior; Economic Development and Cultural Change; Defence and Peace Economics; Journal of Policy Analysis and Management; Criminology; Journal of Quantitative Criminology; Journal of Experimental Criminology; Criminology and Public Policy

SELECTED PRESENTATIONS

Conference and Seminar Presentations

- 2025 UNU-WIDER Tax and Conflict Workshop, Helsinki; The Interconnection of Latin American Policy Challenges, Columbia University, New York
- 2024 UNU-WIDER Research Seminar, Helsinki
- 2023 IEA World Congress, Medellín; IDB Research Seminar, Washington, DC; UNU-WIDER Development Conference, Oslo; NBER Summer Institute: Crime, Cambridge, MA; Texas Economics of Crime Conference, Austin, TX; Seminario CAF; AL CAPONE/RIDGE, Montevideo; Empirical Studies of Conflict, Bogotá
- 2022 American Economics Association Annual Meeting; National Academies Workshop on Building Trust and Legitimacy in Policing; UNU-WIDER Development Conference, Bogotá; American Society of Criminology Annual Meeting, Atlanta; AL CAPONE, Reggio Calabria; UNU-WIDER Puzzle of Peace Conference, Helsinki; CLEAN Seminar; Urban Violence and Collective Memory in the Americas, Geneva; Conference on Criminal Governance, Rio de Janeiro; CIDE Lecture Series on Drug Policy
- 2021 Niskanen Center Panel Series on Violence Prevention; RIDGE Forum: AL CAPONE; Fedesarrollo; UNODC INEGI Conference on Governance, Crime and Justice Statistics; USAID; Center for Global Development Violence Prevention seminar; University of Chicago and LSE Conference on the Economics of Crime and Justice; Universidad Católica de Uruguay Economics Seminar; Congreso Anual Red de Investigadores de Economía
- 2020 BREAD/CEPR/STICERD/TCD Conference on Development Economics; Sao Paulo School of Economics; CEPR RPN on Preventing Conflict; University of Chicago Crime Lab; Empirical Studies of Conflict (ESOC); Texas Economics of Crime Workshop, College Station; Latin America Peace Science, Medellín
- 2019 Annual Colombian Economics Conference, Bogotá; IDB Innovation in Citizen Services Division, Washington, DC; LACEA, Puebla; Universidad EAFIT; What Works Global Summit, México D.F.; REDES DAL, México D.F.; Behavioral Insights in Development and Peace Building, Göttingen; Economic Development and Institutions Annual Conference, Paris; Ministério Público do Estado do Rio de Janeiro; RIDGE Forum: Political Economy Workshop, Medellín; AL CAPONE, Medellín; Cities and Development Workshop, Johns Hopkins SAIS, Washington, DC; International Republican Institute, Panamá; Seminario CEDE CESED, Bogotá
- 2018 Encuentro Internacional de Observatorios del Delito, Policía Nacional, Bogotá; Households in Conflict Network Workshop, Medellín; Escuela de Posgrados de la Policía Nacional, Bogotá; Proantioquia, Medellín

2017	LACEA, Buenos Aires; Economic Development and Institutions Annual Conference, Namur; Economics of Organized Crime, Bogotá; Seminario de Economía, Banco de la República, Medellín; AL CAPONE, Santiago; Empirical Studies of Conflict, Washington, DC; EGAP 20, Bogotá; Seminario CEDE, Universidad de los Andes, Bogotá; National Network for Safe Communities, Tarrytown, NY; Seminario de Economía, Universidad del Rosario, Bogotá
2016	Center for Latin American Studies, Stanford; LACEA, Medellín; University of Chicago Crime Lab; AL CAPONE, Buenos Aires; American Law and Economics Association, Harvard Law School; Seminario Banco de la República, Bogotá
2015	LACEA, Santa Cruz de la Sierra
2014	LACEA, Sao Paulo; Seminario de Economía, Banco de la República, Bogotá
2012	Economías criminales y poder político, Universidad EAFIT, Medellín

GRANTS

2023–24	Innovations for Poverty Action, Human Trafficking Research Initiative, “Understanding Gang Entry and Exit in Medellín, Colombia,” \$118,000
2022–24	Sistema General de Regalías, Gobierno de Colombia, “Estudios sobre pandillas, crimen urbano y gobierno criminal en Antioquia,” \$840,000
2022–23	Templeton World Charity Foundation, “Childhood Adversity, Misperceptions, and Gang Recruitment,” \$235,000
2022	Towards Kindness, “Understanding Gang Entry and Exit in Medellín, Colombia,” \$200,000
2021–23	Ministerio de Ciencia, Tecnología e Innovación, “Crimen urbano y políticas de seguridad en Colombia y América Latina: Reclutamiento, gobierno criminal y policía militarizada,” \$400,000
2022	Interamerican Development Bank, “Building Trust in State Actors: A Multi-Site Experiment with the Colombian National Police,” \$130,000
2020–21	Innovations for Poverty Action Peace and Recovery Program, “Gang Entry and Exit: Behavioral Biases and Gang Recruitment,” \$50,000 Becker Friedman Institute, University of Chicago, “COVID-19, Crises, and Support for the Rule of Law: Organized Crime in Rio de Janeiro’s Favelas,” \$35,000 Foreign and Commonwealth Office, UK, “How Organized Crime Is Responding to the COVID-19 Crisis,” \$35,000 Universidad EAFIT, “Organized Crime in Rio de Janeiro: Understanding Non-State Provision of Order and Justice,” \$40,000
2020	J-PAL Crime and Violence Initiative, “The Other Virus: How Gangs and Organized Crime Are Responding to the COVID-19 Crisis,” \$50,000
2020–23	Universidad EAFIT, “Improving Human Decisions through Machine Learning: An Experiment to Reduce Crime by Selecting Inmates Better,” \$100,000
2019–20	National Science Foundation, SES 1919399, “Contesting Criminal Gang Governance in Medellín: Experimental Impacts of Intensive Municipal Governance and Community Organization on Gang Governance,” \$375,000
2019	J-PAL Crime and Violence Initiative, “Contesting Criminal Gang Governance in Medellín,” \$100,000

	Fundación para el Desarrollo de Antioquia – Proantioquia, “Gangs of Medellin: A Proposal to Map Order and Violence at the Micro Level,” \$70,000
2018	Secretaría de Seguridad de Medellín, “Gangs of Medellin: A Proposal to Map Order and Violence at the Micro Level,” \$33,000 Proantioquia, “Gangs of Medellin: A Proposal to Map Order and Violence at the Micro Level,” \$70,000
2017–18	J-PAL Latin America and Caribbean, “Strategies and Programs to Prevent Violence among Youth,” \$32,000 Economic Development and Institutions – EDI, “Gangs of Medellin: A Proposal to Understand Variation in Non-State Provision of Order and Justice,” \$100,000 CESED/Postobon, Universidad de los Andes, “Gangs of Medellin,” \$10,000 CESED/Open Society Foundations, Universidad de los Andes, “Gangs of Medellin,” \$10,000
2016–17	Development Priorities Window – 3ie, “Increasing State and Police Presence in the Least Governed Areas of Bogotá: A Hot Spot Policing Approach,” \$280,000 J-PAL Governance Initiative, “State-Building on the Intensive and Extensive Margins: Testing Urban Violence Reduction through Policing and Public Services in Bogota,” \$360,000 CAF – Development Bank of Latin America, “The Impact of Hotspot Policing and Municipal Services on Crime: Experimental Evidence from Bogotá,” \$50,000 Government Partnership Initiative – J-PAL, “The Impact of Hotspot Policing and Municipal Services on Crime: Experimental Evidence from Bogotá,” \$20,000
2016	CESED/Postobon, Universidad de los Andes, “Prison Overcrowding and Recidivism: Evidence from Colombia,” \$10,000 CESED/Open Society Foundations, Universidad de los Andes, “El Sistema de Justicia Criminal en la lucha contra el consumo de drogas ilícitas,” \$10,000

NON-ACADEMIC EMPLOYMENT AND CONSULTING

2021–22	Consultant, Police Reform, National Police of Colombia Consultant, Policy Analysis and Evaluation, Federación Nacional de Departamentos Consultant, Impact Evaluation, Fundación Acción Interna
2020–21	Consultant, Human Rights, Human Rights Office, Presidency of Colombia Consultant, Human Trafficking, International Organization for Migration
2019–22	Consultant, Innovation in Citizen Services Division, Inter-American Development Bank
2019	Advisor to the Director for Justice, Security and Government, National Planning Department
2018–19	Advisor on Monitoring and Evaluation, International Organization for Migration
2017–18	Advisor to the Deputy Minister for Crime Policy, Ministry of Justice of Colombia Advisor to the Secretary, Secretariat of Security of Bogotá
2017	Consultant, Innovation in Citizen Services Division, Inter-American Development Bank
2015–16	Consultant, CAF – Latin American Development Bank Consultant, CREER-IHRB Institute for Human Rights and Business
2014–15	Chief of Staff, Senator in the 4th Committee on Economic Affairs, Colombian Congress
2013–14	Advisor, FINAGRO – Rural Development Bank, Colombia

2009–11 Director, Cadastre and Territorial Development, Government of Antioquia, Colombia
2008–09 Director, Economic Development, Government of Antioquia, Colombia